

Part A: Case Study

Selected Type: Cyberbullying

Case Study: The Shadow Profile Harassment

What is the crime?

Cyberbullying in this case is Targeted Online Harassment and Impersonation. This is where a person intentionally and repeatedly causes harm, distress, or damage to another individual through digital technologies. In India, this is governed by Section 78, which deals with Stalking, and Section 356, which deals with Defamation, under the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

How is this crime typically committed? (Step-by-Step):

Selection and Stalking: The bully identifies their victim, who in most cases is a peer, and stalks their social media accounts to gather personal images and information.

Creation of Fake Personas: The bully then creates shadow or finsta accounts using their victim's images.

Dissemination of Information: The bully then disseminates harmful images, hateful comments, and false rumors on these accounts to damage their victim's reputation.

Isolation: The bully may then engage in dogpiling, where they get multiple accounts to harass their victim, thus making them feel trapped in a virtual world.

Who are the victims of this crime?

College students, aged 18-24, are the common victims, especially those with public social media accounts. Statistics from 2025/2026 indicate that nearly 57% of Indian youths have fallen victim to some form of online harassment.

What are the consequences of this crime?

Victim: The victim suffers from extreme psychological trauma, academic underperformance, and social withdrawal.

Perpetrator: The bully risks a jail term of up to 3 years, along with a heavy fine, according to the BNS and IT Act, while the college authorities will rusticate them.